

How to Make a (Free) Data Science Portfolio Website With GitHub Pages

5 easy steps toward your next data science role

Shaw Talebi



Example data science portfolio

[View the Project on GitHub](#)
ShawhinT/example-portfolio

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ZIP File

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TAR Ball

View On
GitHub

Data Scientist

Technical Skills: Python, SQL, AWS, Snowflake, MATLAB

Education

- Ph.D., Physics The University of Texas at Dallas (May 2022)
- M.S., Physics The University of Texas at Dallas (December 2019)
- B.S., Physics The University of Texas at Dallas (May 2017)

Work Experience

Data Scientist @ Toyota Financial Services (June 2022 - Present)

- Uncovered and corrected missing step in production data pipeline which impacted over 70% of active accounts
- Redeveloped loan originations model which resulted in 50% improvement in model performance and saving 1 million dollars in potential losses

Data Science Consultant @ Shawhin Talebi Ventures LLC (December 2020 - Present)

- Conducted data collection, processing, and analysis for novel study evaluating the impact of over 300 biometrics variables on human performance in hyper-realistic, live-fire training scenarios
- Applied unsupervised deep learning approaches to longitudinal ICU data to discover novel sepsis sub-phenotypes

By the end of this article, you will be able to create your own data science portfolio from scratch using GitHub Pages.

Technical Skills Aren't Enough

Getting a job as a data scientist is not all about your programming and ML chops. A big part of getting hired is **selling yourself**. Unfortunately, this tends to be a big weakness for data scientists because we don't typically focus on this skill set in our formal training or day-to-day work. I was definitely in this boat when first looking for data science roles. However, one simple thing that helped me get my current job was **making a portfolio website**.

Aesthetics Go a Long Way

A (pretty) website helps you stand out and gives you credibility as a professional. It gives employers a landing page to learn more about you and your experience. While this all sounds great, if you're a data scientist like me, then web development is probably not your strong suit (as can be seen in the screenshot below).

Shaw Talebi

Data Scientist | Not Web Developer



I am data scientist plz hire me

P.S. for your sake, don't ask me for a website

What happens when a data scientist makes a website. Image by author.

GitHub Pages

Lucky for us all, our good friend GitHub has a solution for this. **GitHub Pages** is a built-in function that **lets you host a website from a GitHub repository for free!**

Furthermore, GitHub Pages is equipped with a package called **Jekyll** which automatically translates your repo's README.md file into a pretty website.

Recent UI change

I used GitHub Pages many times in grad school (2019–2022) to spin up project websites and my own portfolio. However, there was a recent change to the Pages user interface, which **made the process a little different (and less convenient)** than what is

described on the [GitHub Pages website](#). While their outdated instructions sent me down a rabbit hole for a few hours, I finally nailed down a quick and easy (no-code) process for generating a portfolio website. Here I break it into **5 easy steps**, so you don't have to struggle like I did 😊.

Step 1) Create GitHub Repo

The first step is to create a new GitHub repository. An easy way to do this is: go to your GitHub profile > click on *Repositories* > click the green *New* button.

After doing this, you should get a screen like the one below.

Example GitHub repo configurations for a portfolio website. Image by author.

The first thing we need here is to set the repository name. This is important because **it will dictate the default URL for your website**. There are two options here.

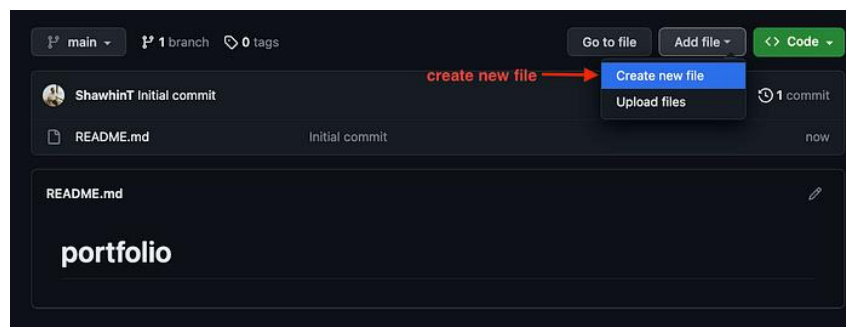
- The **first option** is to use ***username.github.io***. For example, my user name is ShawhinT, so here I would type: shawhint.github.io. With this option, the repo name is identical to the website URL.

- The **second option** is to use **any name** you like. For example, I can name the repo *portfolio*. Then my website URL will be: *shawhint.github.io/portfolio*.

Next, check the *Add a README file* box. Then click *Create repository*.

Step 2) Create `_config.yml` File

The second step is to **select a theme for your website portfolio**. Before the Pages interface change, this consisted of picking a theme using a built-in GUI. However, this is no longer the case, and we now need to pick a theme via something called a `_config.yml` file. This file tells Jekyll how to take the text from our README file and generate a pretty website. To make a `_config.yml` file, create a new file in your repo, as shown in the screenshot below.



How to create new file in GitHub repo. Image by author.

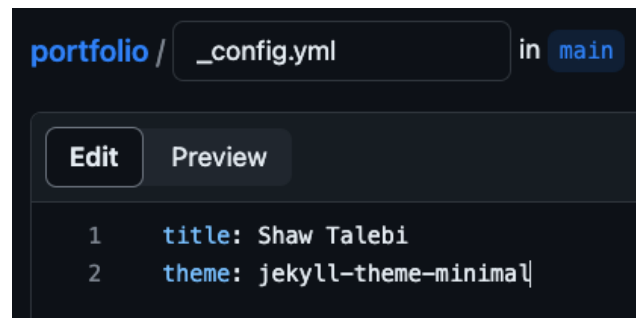
Now name your new file, `_config.yml`, and add the following contents to the file.

add the following to `_config.yml` file

title: YOUR NAME

theme: jekyll-theme-minimal

Here I pick the “minimal” theme, which I like best for a portfolio. But there are other supported theme options. A full list of them can be found here: <https://pages.github.com/themes/>



```
portfolio / _config.yml in main
Edit Preview
1 title: Shaw Talebi
2 theme: jekyll-theme-minimal
```

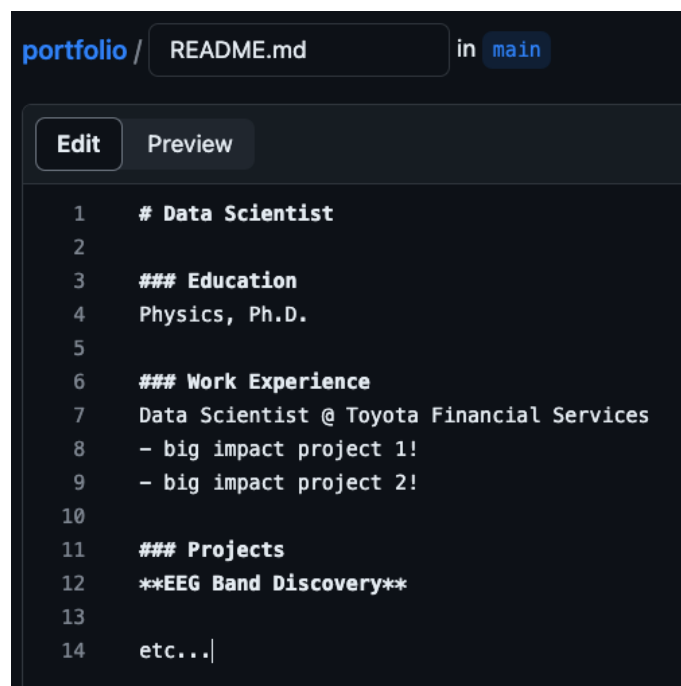
Example config.yml file. Image by author.

Once that’s done, **commit the changes**.

Step 3) Fill out README.md file

The third step is to fill out your README. This will become the content of your portfolio website. For now, we can put in basic information but will return to this later.

The screenshot below shows a basic example of some initial content.



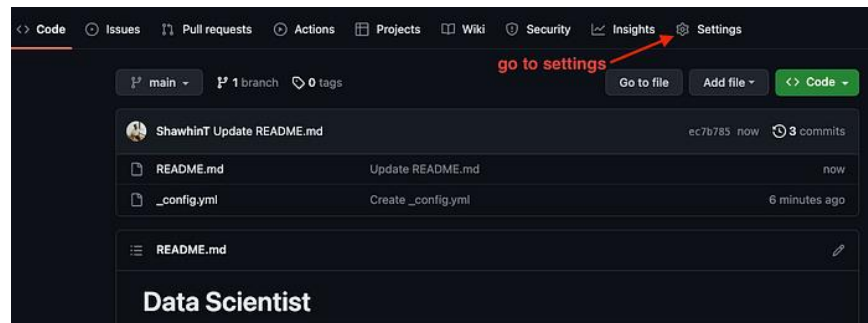
```
portfolio / README.md in main
Edit Preview
1 # Data Scientist
2
3 ### Education
4 Physics, Ph.D.
5
6 ### Work Experience
7 Data Scientist @ Toyota Financial Services
8 - big impact project 1!
9 - big impact project 2!
10
11 ### Projects
12 **EEG Band Discovery**
13
14 etc...|
```

Example README.md file content. Image by author.

Once you have some basic info down, **commit the changes**.

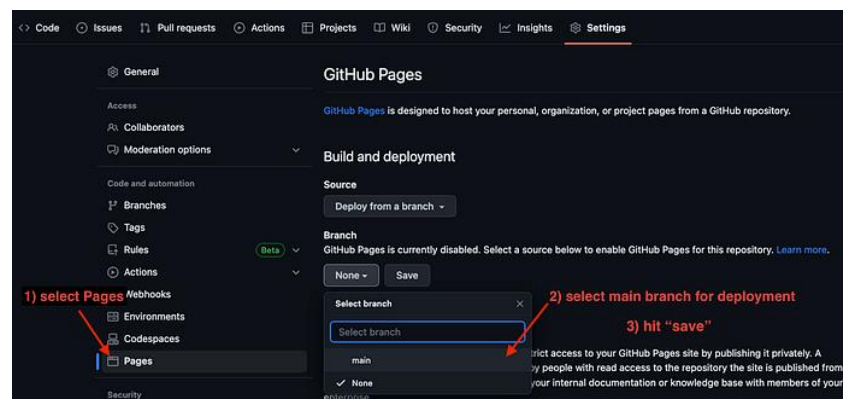
Step 4) Build and Deploy Website

With the `_config.yml` and `README.md` files in place, you can deploy your website. To do this, go to your repo's settings.



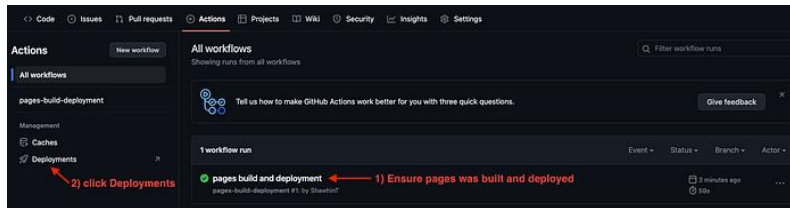
Location of setting tab for GitHub repo. Image by author.

On the left-hand settings panel, click on the *Pages* option. Then, select the main branch as your deployment source and hit *Save*.



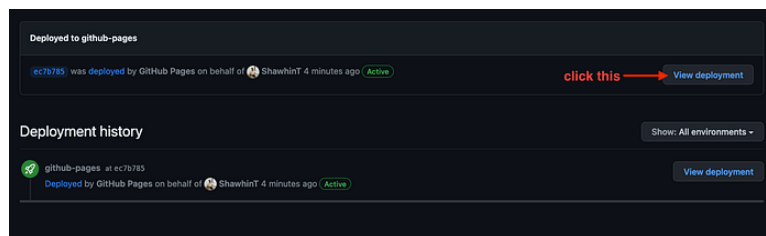
How to deploy website from main branch. Image by author.

Now, we can check the deployment status by navigating to the repo's action tab. Once you see the green check next to *pages build and deployment*, click *Deployments* on the left panel.



How to check deployment status. Image by author.

You'll reach a screen that looks like the screenshot below. From there, simply click *View deployment* to go to your website.



How to view website deployment. Image by author.

Below is an example of what you should be seeing. It is bare-bones for now, but I find it helpful to run through the whole process before going back and filling out the website content.

Shaw Talebi

[View the Project on GitHub](#)
ShawhinT/portfolio

Data Scientist

Education

Physics, Ph.D.

Work Experience

Data Scientist @ Toyota Financial Services

- big impact project 1!
- big impact project 2!

Projects

EEG Band Discovery

etc...

Bare-bones version of portfolio website. Image by author.

Step 5) Customize & Fine-tune

Now that we've seen the whole process, you can go back to your README.md file and customize your portfolio. If you want some inspiration, take a look at a finished example portfolio available at the GitHub repo below👉

Final product: <https://shawhint.github.io/example-portfolio/>

Feel free to steal the code and fill in the portfolio with your own experience. My initial strategy was to copy-paste content from my LinkedIn profile and resume. However, in the [next blog](#) of this series, I will discuss how to make a data science portfolio that will get you hired. In the meantime, if you have questions on this or a career in data science, feel free to reach out 😊.



Written by Shaw Talebi Data Scientist | PhD, Physics

Adapted from: <https://medium.com/the-data-entrepreneurs/how-to-make-a-free-data-science-portfolio-website-with-github-pages-aa1e4965e155>